

W E D N E S D A Y

FLOWERS OR WEEDS?

Hammer

SCRIPTURE TEXT:

**“You shall love the Lord your God with all your heart,
with all your soul, and with all your strength.”**

Deuteronomy 6: 5 (NKJV)



LESSON OBJECTIVE

Weeds grow fast, spread everywhere, and can eventually overtake the real flowers or plants they try to mimic. Some weeds may so closely resemble the actual flower or plant that it is difficult to distinguish between the real flower and the weeds. Can you think of some weeds that look like flowers? If left unattended, weeds will overpower the real flowers or plants and, in some cases, strangle them. However, if we remove weeds and daily care for the real flowers by watering, fertilizing, and exposing them to sunshine, the real flower or plant will stand firm.

God wants us to be real flowers and bring beauty into this world. He made us to reflect His image and His character. However, just like the battle between the flowers and the weeds, we have the battle of good and evil taking place in our homes and in our hearts. Satan is working diligently to disrupt the harmony and sweet aroma in our homes. Every time we say angry words, have grumpy attitudes, yell harsh commands, and disrespect one another, Satan believes he wins. It's a part of the great controversy. Here's the good news! Jesus wins! He's wrestling Satan for us. When we communicate with grace, respect one another, listen patiently, speak kind words, and forgive one another, we claim the victory of Jesus. Commit to rebuilding the family altar in your home daily and pray for Jesus to protect every family member from the tricks of the enemy. **“Love is patient and kind, love does not envy or boast; it is not arrogant or rude.” 1 Corinthians 13:4**



Turning the hearts of the parents to the children.

Read Malachi 4:5-6

This story of Elijah on Mt. Carmel ends with a heart-turning message. It is not just a message of obedience but about a God who loves us and wants the best for our families. Before Elijah prays, he calls the people to come closer to him. Even though they had been disobedient, God doesn't destroy them. God shows them that He longs to have them turn back to Him. True heart-turning turns our hearts towards Jesus Christ, allowing family members to turn towards each other and reflect the warmth of God's love, grace, forgiveness, and acceptance. Rebuilding the family altar means spending more time in prayer and bible study and calling on the Spirit of God to perform a miracle in our homes and in our hearts.

Ellen G. White states, "The cause of division and discord in families and in the church is separation from Christ. To come near to Christ is to come near to one another. The secret to true unity in the church and in the family is not diplomacy not management, not superhuman effort to overcome difficulties—though there will be much of this to do—but union with Christ." The Adventist Home, 179.1. When we rebuild the family altar and make Christ the center of our homes, we enter into a closer relationship with Christ. It is through this relationship that God can make good relationships better and poor relationships good. Successful and healthy family relationships begin by acknowledging the inherent worth of every member of the family. Jesus always affirmed and accepted people regardless of their sins. He showed love and compassion for them, drew them close and then he asked them to repent and follow him.

Wouldn't it be wonderful if everyone in our family felt loved, accepted, understood, and cherished? Imagine what our home environment would be like if we recognized everyone for their own unique gifts and talents and encouraged each to shine in their own way. Envision a home where every child is a favorite and is valued for who they are, and not one feels left

out because he or she isn't like their sibling or exactly like one or both parents. Many times, poor family relationships can be traced to a poor self-concept, either how that person views self and their worth in relation to other family members and their infinite worth in the eyes of God.

Heart turning means allowing God to first change your hearts as fathers, mothers, parents and guardians—the adults in the home—toward your children and others who need to know the one true God. When you look at each family member, put on your Jesus "lenses" and see each one through the tender, and loving eyes of Jesus. Ask God to tear down any walls of hostility, anger, disappointment, and resentment and to give you a heart like Jesus. Before Elijah prayed on Mt. Carmel, he called the people to come closer to him. He didn't despise them publicly or in his heart, he wanted them to experience the abundant, unfailing love of God. For many parents, this may require some repentance to God and apologies to your children for not loving them in the way Jesus teaches us to love.

Call on God, like Elijah, to turn hearts in your home today, especially to the one you think doesn't deserve it. Pray especially for your own children or others who have wandered away from serving the one true God. Parents, ask for an outpouring of the Holy Spirit in your home. Ask God to teach you how to love deeply and unconditionally like He loves us. When this heart-turning takes place in our homes we become modern day Elijahs and can lead our children and others to serve God and prepare for the second coming of our Lord and Savior Jesus Christ.

PRAYER

Dear God, teach us to love like You love us, and please forgive us for those times we have not loved like You. Help us to turn out hearts toward our children and turn our children's hearts toward us. May the warmth of Your love abide in our home, and may we abide with You always. In Jesus' name, amen.



APPLY IT & LIVE IT



BIBLE CHALLENGE

Mid-week
checkpoint:
Recite the
memory verse
together as a
family.



FAMILY TALK

Parents and guardians:

- How are you teaching your children to love Jesus?
- In what ways are you showing your children the true love of Jesus as you talk and interact with them?
- How do your daily decisions convey to your children that they are precious in God's eyes and in yours?
- What small changes can you make today to be more patient, kind, and understanding to your children and family members?

***Note to parents:**

Many research studies on families suggest that parents frequently create a rivalry in families by preferring one child over another. The favorite child is usually the child that is most like the parent(s) or the child that always obeys them. When preferential treatment is consistently focused on one child, it can become unhealthy, leaving the non-favored child vulnerable to depression, or the favored child begins to feel responsible for the parent's happiness. Commit to making everyone in your home your "favorite."



REBUILDING THE FAMILY ALTAR

Heart-turning takes time, but it doesn't require as much time as you think. Simple activities like one-on-one bonding can be done daily with a little extra thought and effort. Parents (two-parents, single parents, grandparents, guardians) today is your day for heart-turning, so try one of these activities and have fun!

ONE-ON-ONE BONDING ACTIVITY:

Ask your child or children individually what activity (not homework) they would like to do only with you (not with other family members) for just 15 minutes every day. If it's a reasonable

ask, financially feasible, and physically possible, schedule time to do this activity with your child. Ask your child what special activity they would like to do once a month, just the two of you, and schedule a time to do this activity together. Remember this is a one-on-one activity—one parent, one child.

15-MINUTE BONDING IDEAS: Read a book, work on a puzzle, play a game inside or outside, go for a walk, listen attentively without speaking, scolding, or giving advice, and share your spiritual journey.

MONTHLY BONDING IDEAS: Have breakfast together on Sunday morning at a favorite eatery, have a picnic together, build or make something, go shopping, go to a concert, or watch a

favorite sports team, go camping or hiking, go to a lake or mountain and spend time talking about our Creator God.

Remember, parents, there should be no judgment during these activities; listen more and talk less. This is especially important for your early adolescents and teens. When you talk about God, allow them to share their spiritual struggles, doubts, and questions in a safe space. Bonding time is an opportunity to foster warmth and affection and build greater trust between parent and child. Children see God through their parents. They will catch your values if you are consistent with family worship, your own devotional time and your love.